

Healthy Oceans

New Zealand is responsible for one of the world's largest ocean territories, yet too many of our marine ecosystems are in decline.

We manage the fifth-largest Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) in the world—over 4 million square kilometres, 15 times our land mass—with some of the most diverse marine life on the planet. Yet we protect less than 0.5% of our waters as marine reserves, allow destructive fishing practices that harm critical ecosystems, and manage our fisheries with outdated approaches that prioritise short-term extraction over long-term abundance. Over 81% of New Zealanders want to see marine protection expanded, but current policies fall far short of this mandate.

At Opportunity we know we can do better.

We will place biodiversity at the centre of marine policy; protecting more marine ecosystems, restoring fish stocks and growing a sustainable blue economy that creates high-value jobs and restores our oceans for future generations.

This is an investment in abundant fisheries, thriving coastal communities, healthy and resilient marine ecosystems, and economic opportunities that honour both our environmental responsibilities and our obligations under Te Tiriti o Waitangi.

Our reforms will:

- Transform fisheries management from single-species quotas to ecosystem-based approaches that ensure genuine sustainability
- Manage inshore and offshore fisheries differently
- Invest in blue economy initiatives including sustainable aquaculture, land-based aquaculture, coastal restoration, and marine research
- Create new, fit-for-purpose marine protection tools by replacing the Marine Reserves Act 1971
- Expand marine protected areas from 0.5% to 30% of our ocean territory through science-based, Treaty-consistent, community-led marine spatial planning
- Phase out destructive bottom trawling in all inshore areas by 2030
- Install cameras on all commercial fishing vessels (including the deep water fleet) to ensure transparency and responsible fishing practice
- Establish integrated ocean governance through a reinstated Ocean Secretariat with cross-agency coordination
- Permanently ban seabed mining in New Zealand waters

Opportunity's Healthy Oceans agenda will enable:

- Restored fish abundance for commercial, recreational, and customary fishers through ecosystem-based management that increases target stock levels from 40% to 50% of virgin biomass
- Protection of 30% of our ocean territory, enabling the enduring abundance and resilience in our unique marine ecosystems
- 10,000+ hectares of coastal habitat restored through wetland, mangrove, and seagrass programmes that sequester carbon and rebuild fish nurseries
- \$500 million+ annual blue economy growth from sustainable aquaculture, marine biotechnology, and ocean-based tourism
- Transparent and accountable commercial fisheries with 100% observer coverage through the deployment of cameras on boats and independent monitoring
- Enhanced customary and recreational access to abundant fish stocks in restored marine environments
- Reduced carbon emissions through protected blue carbon ecosystems and phasing out destructive and indiscriminate fishing practices like bottom-trawling

The problems we're solving

We are letting our marine ecosystems be pillaged for short-term gain

The government reports that 87% of fish stocks are in "good shape" but local communities and recreational fishers are watching their catch decline year after year. The disconnect stems from alarmingly low measures of sustainability for our fish species. Instead of making sure our children inherit thriving, abundant ecosystems, we've locked in a management system that encourages depletion. At the heart of the problem is our quota management system, which is not functional. At the same time, New Zealand is an outlier among our friends in allowing indiscriminate, destructive practices like bottom-trawling. Destruction of coral reefs



and seafloor ecosystems, noise and light pollution and sediment plumes promise damage that will take decades to recover from, if it does at all.

The standards we impose on the fishing industry are poorly enforced. Despite clear evidence that cameras dramatically improve transparency and accountability, the current government refuses to install them on deep-sea trawlers—the very vessels operating in the most remote and ecologically sensitive areas.

The real economic gains from a blue economy are left on the table

New Zealand's current short-sighted approach to managing our blue economy locks us into extractive industries that add less value than they could to the wider economy. Between 60% and 90% of our commercial catch is exported, much of it without any value-add processing. Frozen fish fingers are not a route to national prosperity.

Our blue economy is brimming with potential: increased value-add for fish and other marine products, aquaculture, tourism and biotechnology. These industries offer growth and well-paid jobs, while at the same time ensuring a healthy marine environment for generations to come.

Our oceans are managed in silos, not as ecosystems

New Zealand's marine environment is governed by a fragmented web of agencies and legislation. This siloed approach means no single agency is responsible for the health of our ocean as an integrated ecosystem.

The consequences are stark. Current marine reserves are considered poorly designed and inefficiently placed to achieve conservation objectives. Fisheries management focuses on individual species without considering ecosystem impacts, and many decisions are based on limited or outdated science. Agricultural runoff—which carries pesticides and fertilizers—pours into coastal waters with minimal treatment, creating sediment plumes visible from space after heavy rainfall events.

The Healthy Oceans policy pillars

1. Transform fisheries management for genuine sustainability

1.1 Shift from quota management to ecosystem-based fisheries management

The current Quota Management System focuses on managing individual species in isolation, missing crucial ecosystem relationships and cumulative impacts. We will implement a comprehensive review of fisheries management to enable ecosystem-



based approaches, drawing on international best practice and New Zealand-specific solutions like the Rescue Fish / Ika Rauora pathway developed by LegaSea and NZ Sport Fishing.

Our reform of the fisheries management system will maintain the economic benefits of secure catch entitlements while adding ecosystem health requirements, bycatch limits, habitat protection measures, and adaptive management that responds to ecosystem changes rather than managing each species in isolation.

1.2 Raise sustainability baselines to ensure fish abundance

Current baselines for “sustainable” fishing are far too low. We will increase:

- Management targets from 40% to 50% of virgin biomass levels
- Soft limits (below which stocks are considered depleted) from 20% to 40%
- Hard limits (triggering immediate action) from 10% to 20%

These increased targets align with best international practice and the recommendations of environmental and fishing advocacy groups. They will ensure fish stocks are genuinely abundant rather than merely “not collapsed” and are able to sustain wider ecosystem needs, supporting better outcomes for commercial, recreational, and customary fishers alike.

1.3 Install cameras and maintain observers on all commercial fishing vessels

Transparency is non-negotiable for sustainable fisheries. We will urgently roll out cameras to commercial fishing vessels over 8m in length, including deep-sea trawlers and scampi boats currently exempt under the present government’s programme.

Camera footage will be independently reviewed to verify catch reporting, monitor bycatch of protected species, ensure compliance with fishing rules, and provide data for scientific stock assessments. This is not about distrusting fishers—it’s about creating the comprehensive monitoring infrastructure that modern fisheries management requires.

Cameras alone cannot capture everything happening on a fishing vessel. We will maintain programmes for independent observers on commercial boats to provide detailed scientific data, monitor compliance, and ensure fishers operate according to best practices.

1.4 Phase out bottom trawling

Bottom trawling in sensitive ecosystems delivers short-term catch at the cost of long-term ecosystem destruction. We will implement a staged phase-out of bottom contact fishing methods such as trawling, dredging and Danish seining, including:

- Immediate closures in the Hauraki Gulf and other inshore areas facing critical ecosystem decline
- Three-year phase-out on all seamounts, where New Zealand is the only South Pacific nation still permitting this practice
- Five-year phase-out on other deep-sea features including cold-water coral habitats and vulnerable benthic ecosystems

This phase-out will be supported by transition assistance for affected fishing operators, including support to retrain, retool for alternative fishing methods, or exit the industry with dignity.

1.5 Increase conservation services cost recovery to invest in restoration

The Fisheries (Cost Recovery) Rules 2001 (and Amendment 2023) require commercial fishers to pay for fisheries management costs, but rates for conservation services remain below what's needed for genuine marine restoration and ongoing scientific research. Currently, the commercial fishing industry levies cover less than half of the funding needed to monitor, enforce and administer the fishery. Opportunity envisages a 'beneficiary pays' system, whereby 'resource rentals' will be implemented to fund ongoing biodiversity restoration within the EEZ.

These increased charges—structured to maintain fishing industry viability while ensuring appropriate contribution to ecosystem restoration—will fund marine protected area management, threatened species recovery programmes, habitat restoration, and research to ensure commercially fished ecosystems remain healthy and productive for future generations.



2. Expand marine protection

2.1 Develop a Marine Protected Area expansion plan

New Zealand's 44 marine reserves cover just over 17,000 square kilometres—less than 0.5% of our 4-million-square-kilometre EEZ.

Public support for marine protection is clear and strong across all parties, but progress requires long-term commitment beyond electoral cycles. We will work across Parliament to develop a strategic plan to expand marine protected areas from the current 0.5% to:

- 20% by 2030 (intermediate target)
- 30% by 2035 (aligned with international best practice and commitments)

This expansion will be designed using systematic conservation planning that balances biodiversity protection with economic considerations. Research shows we can protect 86% of threatened species while maintaining 86% of current fishing catch—but only with strategic placement based on robust science.

2.2 Replace the Marine Reserves Act with flexible, modern legislation

The 54-year-old Marine Reserves Act offers only one tool—complete no-take marine reserves—and creates cumbersome, adversarial processes. We will replace it with modern legislation providing a suite of flexible spatial management tools:

- High-protection marine reserves (no extractive activity)
- Multiple-use marine protected areas (allows for ecosystem regeneration with some fishing activity)
- Species management areas (protecting specific threatened species while allowing compatible activities)
- Seafloor protection zones (prohibiting bottom-impact fishing while allowing other activities)
- Emergency closure areas (temporary protections responding to ecosystem stress)
- Sustainable-use zones (managed for long-term ecosystem health with sustainable harvest)
- Statutory recognition of customary tools like rāhui

This flexibility will allow protection measures tailored to local ecological needs and community values, reducing conflict and enabling faster, more effective implementation.

2.3 Implement protection planning in partnership with local communities

Marine protection imposed by central government without community involvement creates resistance and compliance problems. We will resource genuine partnership processes bringing together:

- Local iwi and hapū exercising kaitiakitanga
- Commercial and recreational fishing communities
- Tourism operators and marine industries

- Conservation groups and marine scientists
- Local councils and regional communities

These collaborative planning processes will identify local priorities, incorporate mātauranga Māori and local knowledge alongside Western science, design protection measures that respect existing uses where possible, and build community ownership of marine protection outcomes.

2.4 Deliver targeted investment for priority threatened species

Beyond spatial protection, some threatened marine species require direct conservation intervention. We will fund recovery programmes for:

- Seabirds including albatross, petrels, and penguins facing risk of bycatch, depleted food sources and degraded habitat
- Marine mammals including New Zealand sea lions and southern right whales
- Māui and Hector's dolphins (the world's rarest dolphins)
- Threatened fish species including mako sharks and Antarctic toothfish

These programmes will combine spatial protection, bycatch reduction, predator control, habitat restoration, food source management and where needed, direct population management to bring threatened species back from the brink.

2.5 Support blue corridors for migratory species in the Pacific and ratify the High Seas Treaty

As a nation with deep Pacific connections, extensive fishing interests, and world-leading marine science capability, New Zealand should be at the forefront of global ocean governance, not trailing behind.

Marine species don't respect national boundaries. Many migrate across vast distances, connecting ecosystems throughout the Pacific. Regional blue corridor initiatives—coordinated networks of protected areas across multiple nations' waters—will protect:

- Whale species moving between feeding and breeding grounds
- Tuna and other highly migratory fish supporting Pacific island economies
- Seabirds that forage across entire ocean basins
- Sea turtles connecting nesting beaches with foraging grounds

The High Seas Treaty creates the first legal framework for protecting international waters beyond any country's EEZ. We will support legislation to ratify the Treaty and actively participate in establishing marine protected areas and sustainable management in the high seas.

2.6 Oppose seabed mining in New Zealand waters

The ecological risks of seabed mining are profound, the potential benefits are speculative, and once ecosystems are destroyed, restoration may be impossible. We will oppose all seabed mining applications in New Zealand's territorial sea and EEZ.

3. Invest in the blue economy and coastal restoration

3.1 Implement recommendations from Sustainable Seas research

The Sustainable Seas National Science Challenge produced comprehensive research on developing New Zealand's blue economy—marine activities that generate economic value while contributing positively to social, cultural, and ecological wellbeing. We will implement the nine concluding recommendations from this research programme, which provide an evidence-based roadmap for:

- Expanding sustainable aquaculture beyond traditional species
- Developing marine biotechnology and innovation sectors
- Growing ocean-based tourism that supports rather than degrades marine environments
- Diversifying coastal economies away from extractive industries
- Integrating Māori values and governance into blue economy development

3.2 Expand sustainable aquaculture including regenerative practices

Aquaculture can produce high-value protein with far lower environmental impacts than land-based farming—when done sustainably. In particular, land-based aquaculture offers a significant opportunity to supply sustainable, high quality fish products locally and internationally while eliminating biosecurity risks and marine pollution. We will support expansion of:

- Seaweed farming that sequesters carbon, absorbs excess nutrients, and provides high-value products from food to bioplastics
- Shellfish aquaculture that filters water and creates habitat while producing premium seafood
- Land-based recirculating aquaculture systems (RAS) for finfish that eliminate biosecurity risks and marine pollution
- Integrated multi-trophic aquaculture that combines species in ways mimicking natural ecosystems

This will be coupled with strengthened environmental standards ensuring aquaculture genuinely enhances rather than degrades coastal ecosystems.

3.3 Restore coastal ecosystems as nature-based solutions

Coastal vegetation—wetlands, mangroves, seagrass meadows, and salt marshes—sequesters carbon at rates far exceeding terrestrial forests while providing critical ecosystem services like storm surge protection and mitigating sea level rise. We will invest in:

- Wetland restoration reconnecting degraded coastal areas with natural water flows
- Seagrass restoration rebuilding meadows that serve as fish nurseries and carbon sinks
- Riparian planting along waterways to reduce sediment and nutrient runoff before it reaches the ocean

These restored habitats will sequester carbon, reduce coastal erosion, filter pollution, rebuild fish stocks, and increase coastal resilience to climate change—delivering multiple benefits from single investments.

3.4 Support iwi and hapū-led marine management initiatives

Māori authority over marine environments is both a Te Tiriti obligation and an opportunity to restore healthier relationships with the ocean. We will:

- Resource iwi and hapū to develop and implement marine management plans in their rohe moana
- Support customary management tools including rāhui, mātaihai reserves, and taiāpure
- Fund initiatives led by hapū that restore coastal ecosystems and revitalise traditional practices
- Ensure Ocean and fisheries management reforms reflect Te Ao Māori perspectives and mātauranga Māori
- Repeal the Marine and Coastal Area (Takutai Moana) (Customary Marine Title) Amendment Act 2025

This recognises that many iwi and hapū are already leading innovative marine management, often filling gaps left by central government, and deserve resourcing to continue and expand this work.

3.5 Add value to catch rather than exporting commodities

New Zealand exports over 90% of our commercial catch, much of it as frozen whole fish with minimal value-added processing. This commodity export model creates relatively few jobs and captures little of the potential economic value.

We will use existing mechanisms including the Sustainable Food and Fibre Futures fund to support innovation that adds value to fish caught in New Zealand waters—from advanced processing and preservation techniques to premium branded products and direct-to-consumer (including domestic) distribution models. This will create high-skilled jobs, increase export revenue per tonne of fish caught, and reduce incentives to maximise catch volume.

4. Establish integrated ocean governance

4.1 Reinstate an Ocean Secretariat with future generations priority

Four separate agencies operating under different statutory frameworks cannot deliver the integrated ecosystem management our oceans require. We will reinstate an Ocean Secretariat with statutory authority to provide cohesive, cross-agency advice on ocean management, economic development, and biodiversity regeneration. This Secretariat will be explicitly mandated to prioritise the interests of future generations, applying intergenerational equity principles to all marine policy decisions. It will coordinate between MPI, DOC, regional councils, the EPA, and other agencies to ensure that fisheries decisions account for ecosystem health, marine protection planning considers economic impacts, and coastal development respects marine biodiversity. It will be an independent, cross-sector convening body resourced

to convene stakeholders, coordinate strategy, and steward long-term change. It will be initially tasked with establishing a sustainable/regenerative oceans strategy to help unify ocean-related legislation, agencies, and economic pathways.

4.2 Invest in open-access marine research and data infrastructure

Evidence-based ocean management requires robust science and accessible data. We will establish a national open-access ocean data platform bringing together marine research, citizen science observations, commercial fishing data, and environmental monitoring in a single accessible system.

This platform will support researchers, community groups, iwi, local councils, and the fishing industry in making informed decisions. Paired with increased investment in marine research—including dedicated funding for long-term ecosystem monitoring, threatened species programmes, and blue economy innovation—this will ensure New Zealand leads the world in marine science and sustainable ocean management.

4.3 Develop long-term regional ocean plans in partnership with communities

Effective ocean governance requires local knowledge, community buy-in, and long-term planning horizons. We will work with regional councils, iwi, fishing communities, and conservation groups to develop 20-year regional ocean plans for key areas including the Hauraki Gulf, Tasman/Golden Bays, Marlborough Sounds, Fiordland, and the Subantarctic.

These plans will establish clear priorities, allocate resources, define accountability mechanisms, and create pathways for ongoing community involvement in decisions affecting their marine environments. They will integrate across land-sea boundaries, addressing upstream sources of marine pollution while planning for coastal resilience in the face of climate change.

Healthy Oceans—Frequently Asked Questions

How much will this cost?

This policy includes both operational expenditure and strategic investments that will be largely cost-neutral or positive to the Crown in the long term. Some costs will be able to be cost-recovered from the commercial fishing industry.

In the short term we estimate an overall annual cost to government of no more than \$100 million. Larger items within this total include funding for coastal ecosystem restoration, marine research and blue economy development initiatives.

How will this affect recreational fishers?

Recreational fishing will improve significantly under these reforms. By raising sustainability baselines from 40% to 50% of virgin biomass, phasing out destructive bottom trawling, and protecting critical habitats, we will restore fish abundance throughout New Zealand waters.

Marine protected areas, while restricting fishing in specific locations, create “spillover effects” where increased fish populations inside reserves seed adjacent areas with more and larger fish. International evidence consistently shows that well-designed marine protection benefits recreational fishing.

The transition away from bottom trawling will particularly benefit recreational fishers by protecting seafloor habitats that juvenile fish depend on, leading to better catch rates across popular recreational species.

Will this hurt commercial fishing operators?

The reforms are designed to ensure long-term viability of commercial fishing by maintaining healthy ecosystems and abundant fish stocks. Research shows we can protect 86% of threatened species while maintaining 86% of current fishing catch through strategic planning.

The commercial fishing sector as a whole will benefit from:

- More abundant and stable fish stocks due to higher sustainability baselines
- Enhanced international reputation and market access from world-leading sustainability standards
- Reduced risk of ecosystem collapse that would trigger much more severe restrictions
- Support for value-added processing that increases revenue per tonne of catch

Three companies currently control 60% of fishing quota, meaning much of any short-term adjustment will fall on large, well-resourced corporations rather than small operators.

What about iwi interests in commercial fishing?

Māori have a significant interest in commercial fishing and are therefore likely to be significantly affected by our reforms. Opportunity fully supports maintaining the integrity of the Māori Fisheries Settlement through a transition in our fishing practices. But that does not mean the transition does not need to happen; including to ensure the sustained operation of commercial fisheries themselves.

We have proposed a range of measures to support the transition that are likely to directly benefit hapu and iwi, including community-based planning, direct support for more sustainable blue economy activities and coastal regeneration initiatives.

What about Māori customary fishing rights?

All reforms will be implemented in a manner fully respecting Māori fishing rights established under the Treaty of Waitangi (Fisheries Claims) Settlement Act 1992 and related agreements. This includes protecting customary fishing rights (and in fact benefiting them from increased fish abundance).

Māori will also be full partners in marine protection planning processes. Many iwi and hapū are already leading innovative marine management that exceeds government standards. These reforms will support and learn from that leadership rather than override it.

What about jobs in fishing communities?

This policy will create more jobs in coastal communities, not fewer. While some employment will shift from destructive practices toward sustainable alternatives, total marine sector employment will grow through:

- Expanded sustainable aquaculture creating new high-value jobs
- Coastal restoration programmes employing local workers
- Value-added seafood processing replacing commodity exports
- Marine research and monitoring generating skilled positions
- Ocean-based tourism benefiting from healthier marine environments
- Blue economy innovation in marine biotechnology and related sectors

Transition support for workers affected by bottom trawling phase-outs will ensure nobody is left behind, with retraining and alternative employment assistance for those who need it.

How does this relate to climate change?

Healthy oceans are critical climate allies. This policy supports climate action through:

- Blue carbon sequestration: Restored coastal wetlands, mangroves, and seagrass meadows sequester carbon at rates exceeding terrestrial forests
- Reduced emissions: Phasing out bottom trawling eliminates carbon dioxide release from disturbed seabed sediments
- Climate resilience: Healthy ecosystems are more resilient to marine heatwaves, ocean acidification, and other climate impacts
- Reduced fossil fuel dependence: Supporting New Zealand fishing vessels to catch for domestic high-value markets rather than distant export markets reduces fuel consumption

For comprehensive climate policy including renewable energy and emissions reduction, see our Energy and Climate policies.

What about offshore renewables like wind farms?

Offshore renewable energy development must be carefully managed to avoid conflicts with marine protection and fishing interests. Our approach:

- Offshore wind and other marine renewable energy will be addressed in regional ocean plans developed with community input
- Marine renewable energy can be compatible with ocean protection when sited appropriately
- Some offshore structures can create artificial reef effects benefiting marine life
- Strategic planning ensures renewable energy, fishing, conservation, and other ocean uses are integrated rather than treated in isolation

For detail on offshore renewable energy development, see our Energy policy.

What about offshore mining of critical minerals? Isn't it hypocritical to support renewable energy generation but not extraction of the minerals needed to support it?

The only critical mineral realistically likely to be produced from seabed mining in New Zealand is vanadium (which occurs alongside iron-sands). Other deposits are far too deep or otherwise inaccessible for realistic extraction in the foreseeable future.

Vanadium can be (but is not currently in NZ) extracted from vanadium slag; a byproduct of our steel industry. Emerging technology promises less environmentally harmful methods for extracting vanadium from byproducts of domestic steel production - this seems like a much more promising option for producing vanadium.

Why not keep the status quo when marine species are not declining towards extinction?

They are declining towards functional extinction, meaning they are not sufficiently abundant or diverse to carry out their function and risk broader ecosystem collapse. For example, when there are not enough reef predators like snapper and crayfish, conditions are right for kina barrens, where sea urchins graze down the kelp and leave bare rock. Other organisms leave because they have no shelter and diversity declines.